

## ASSAM MOVEMENT

### An Open Border

The key factor in the current Assam agitation is the influx of a large number of foreigners into the state, mostly from Bangladesh. Assam agitators estimate the annual infiltration at 3,00,000. India's border with Bangladesh is about 3,000 km running through five states—Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, Mizoram and West Bengal. Rich and fertile Assam is the ultimate El Dorado for many a famished Bangladeshi. Some of them enter Assam directly through the 231 km Indo-Bangladesh border running along the Goalpara district (147 km) on the North-western flank of Assam and Cachar (84 km) on the south. Others cross through the borders along neighbouring Meghalaya, West Bengal and Tripura and move to Assam. The leaders of the Assam agitation allege that border control are lax, providing unlimited opportunities for would-be infiltrators. The Central and state governments recently have taken steps to strengthen the policing along the frontiers.

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that began in the 1920s, of land-hungry peasants from East Bengal to sparsely-populated Assam. It intensified when Hindu refugees joined the flow. Identifying a Bangladeshi is not a simple matter because of extensive blurring between citizens and non-citizens. No wonder that the Illegal Migrants (Determination by Tribunals) Act (IMDT) passed by Parliament in 1983 gave Bangladeshi nationals, suspected of illegally entering Assam, the protection of a quasi-judicial process. Given the difficulties of identifying foreigners, the Assam Accord was impossible to implement. Striking down the IMDT law as unconstitutional, even the Supreme Court in July 2005 sharply criticised the government's failure to stop illegal immigration.

The movement created fault-lines in Assam's social and cultural fabric. Things came to a head in Nellie in February 1983 when, amidst tensions during an election that campaigners portrayed as Assam's last struggle for survival, hundreds were killed. Relations between Hindus and Muslims ruptured and a number of tribal groups launched movements seeking autonomy. Anyone occupying land labelled forests or public land—even the most indigenous of Assamese—now risked being labelled an encroacher. The enduring legacy of the failure of the movement is the United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) which came into existence in 1979. ULFA's position on foreigners is accommodative but it views the failure of the Assam Accord as evidence of Assamese interests being disregarded in the Indian political dispensation.

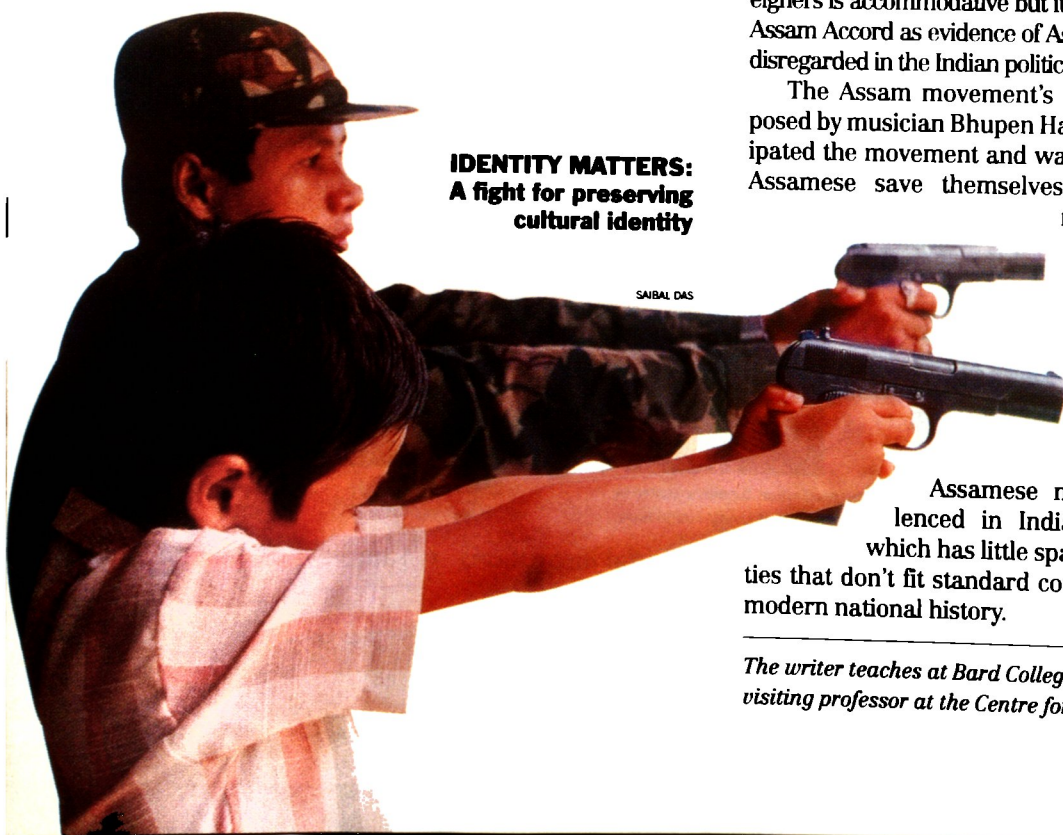
The Assam movement's unofficial song, composed by musician Bhupen Hazarika in 1968, anticipated the movement and warned that "unless the Assamese save themselves, they will become refugees in their own land". Another version of the song expressed pride that there are "martyrs now who can say that if Assam dies, we too shall die".

This part of the Assamese memory remains silenced in Indian public discourse which has little space for regional realities that don't fit standard constructions of India's modern national history.

**1985**  
was the year  
when the Assam  
Accord was  
signed, ending  
the agitation

**IDENTITY MATTERS:**  
A fight for preserving  
cultural identity

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